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The Cradle

My four-and-a-half-decade-long journey in the army started in January 1961. I was all of fifteen years and three months old at that time, and like most others of my age, didn't know where this journey would end. Along with my half-brother, I left home for the National Defence Academy (NDA), Khadakwasla, near Poona, to join the 25th Course. Mother prayed for us and did the 'ardas' before we left. I don't know of any other case where two brothers joined the NDA in the same batch. Though my brother, S.J.S. Marwah (Satti to me), was elder to me by almost two years, we got through the NDA examination and the interview by the selection board together. I was fifteenth in the overall merit list from amongst a couple of thousand who sat for the entrance examination. In those days, the results used to be published in the national dailies. Sadly, it's not the case any longer. Satti opted for the air force, while I chose the army, though I liked the navy too.

The NDA is a world-class training institution; importantly, it is one of the few tri-service academies of the world. It was the vision of Jawaharlal Nehru that resulted in the creation of such an outstanding academy. Today it is the cradle of our military leadership.

We travelled by train for a day-and-a-half from Ferozepur, where my father happened to be posted at that time, and reached Poona on the appointed day. There we were received by a team from the NDA. After an hour's bus ride we reached the academy. I remember that moment so vividly even today.

The first view of the NDA from the main gate at the top of the hill was simply stunning. A straight and wide avenue led us to the heart